THE SERVANT'S GOAL

What to Do While the Master Is Away

A Study of Matthew 25

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Scripture quotations from the King James Version of the Bible.

For Sharan.

Thirty-four years of faithfulness
is its own kind of sermon.

Introduction: The Question He Left Behind

> *"Watch therefore, for ye know neither the day nor the hour."*
> — Matthew 25:13

The master is gone. The door is open. What now?

There is a peculiar silence that follows a departure. Anyone who has ever seen someone they love walk out of a room for the last time knows it. The space they occupied doesn't immediately fill. It just sits there, charged, as though waiting for instructions.

Matthew 25 lives in that silence.

Three parables, told back to back, all circling the same moment: the master has left, the servants are alone, and the question hanging in the air is not theological. It is practical. What do you do now? How do you live in the gap between the departure and the return?

Most of us, if we are honest, have not thought hard about that question. We have thought about the departure — we know the story of the cross, the resurrection, the ascension. We have thought about the return — we have our convictions about what that will look like, our timelines and our expectations. But the gap? The long middle? The Tuesday afternoon of history where we actually live?

That's the part we tend to improvise.

Matthew 25 does not let us improvise. It gives us three stories, told in sequence, that together answer a single question: what does a faithful servant do while the master is away?

The first story is about readiness. Ten young women wait for a wedding. Five of them are ready when the call comes. Five are not. The difference is not talent or goodness or sincerity — it is preparation. Readiness is not an attitude. It is a condition. You either have the oil or you don't.

The second story is about faithfulness in the work. A wealthy man leaves on a journey and distributes his resources among three servants. Two of them put the money to work. One buries it. When the master returns, the verdict is swift and clear — not harsh, but exact. The servant who buried his talent did not commit some dramatic crime. He simply refused to move. He was afraid, and so he was useless.

The third story is the most uncomfortable of all. The Son of Man separates the nations like a shepherd separating sheep from goats. The criterion is not doctrine, not church attendance, not sincerity of belief. It is whether they fed the hungry, gave water to the thirsty, took in the stranger, clothed the naked, visited the sick and the imprisoned. And the shock that runs through both groups — the sheep and the goats alike — is the same: Lord, when? When did we see you? The righteous served him without knowing it. The condemned ignored him without knowing it. He was disguised as the least of these all along.

Watch. Work. Serve. Those three verbs are what this book is about.

They are also, in the author's experience, the three things most easily deferred. It is easy to say you will be ready when the time comes. It is easy to say you will get to work once conditions improve. It is easy to say you care about the least of these without ever actually going to where they are.

Matthew 25 does not let us defer. It sets a clock — not a date, but a certainty — and then asks us to live accordingly.

This book walks through the chapter slowly, a section at a time, trying to hear what it actually says rather than what we have been told it says. You may find that some of it is more demanding than you

expected. You may also find that some of it is more gracious. The God of this chapter is exacting but not cruel. He gives each servant exactly what that servant can handle. He meets the faithful with joy, not just approval. And he identifies so completely with the hungry and the outcast that serving them is, in the most literal sense, serving him.

The master is away. The door is open.

What will you do with the time?

PART ONE

Watch

The Ten Virgins — Matthew 25:1–13

Chapter 1

All Ten Went Out

> *"Then shall the kingdom of heaven be likened unto ten virgins, which took their lamps, and went forth to meet the bridegroom."*
>
> — Matthew 25:1

They all meant to be ready. Meaning to is not the same thing as being.

The first thing to notice about the parable of the ten virgins is what it does not say. It does not say that five of them were believers and five were not. It does not say that five were good people and five were bad people. It does not say that five took the faith seriously and five treated it as a joke.

It says five were wise and five were foolish. The distinction is narrower than we might expect, and that is exactly the point.

All ten of them went out. All ten of them took their lamps. All ten of them were waiting for the same bridegroom. Their intent was identical. Their commitment, to all outward appearances, was the same. They had done the right thing. They had shown up. They were in position.

This matters because it cuts against the comfortable reading of the parable, which is that it is about obvious unbelievers or obvious hypocrites. It is not. The foolish virgins were not pretenders. They were not infiltrators. They were people who genuinely intended to be ready and simply failed to take the last step that would have made them so.

That last step is oil. And oil, in this parable, is the one thing that cannot be improvised at midnight.

We will spend more time on the oil in the next chapter. For now, sit with the image: ten young women, identical in their visible commitment, identical in their location, identical in their hope — and the difference between them is invisible until the moment it becomes everything.

Christian communities are full of people like this. People who went out. People who showed up. People who took their lamps and genuinely intended to be waiting when the bridegroom came. The question the parable presses on us is not whether we intend to be ready. The question is whether we have done the actual work of readiness, or whether we are trusting our intention to carry us through a moment that intention alone cannot survive.

Intention is not preparation. Attending church is not the same as knowing God. Having the right answers on the right occasions is not the same as having oil in your vessel. And the tragedy of the foolish virgins is not that they were dishonest or cruel or faithless in any dramatic sense. It is simply that when the moment of testing came, their readiness turned out to be a posture, not a condition.

They all went out. That part was real. But going out is only the beginning.

The parable asks us to look past our own good intentions and ask a harder question: if the cry came tonight — if the midnight call rang out right now — would we have what we need? Not what we plan to have. Not what we mean to have. What we actually have.

Ten went out. Five came in. The difference was made long before midnight.

Chapter 2

The Oil You Cannot Borrow

> *"But the wise answered, saying, Not so; lest there be not enough for us and you: but go ye rather to them that sell, and buy for yourselves."*
>
> — Matthew 25:9

Faith is not transferable. Some things cannot be shared at midnight.

The refusal of the wise virgins has troubled readers for a long time. It seems uncharitable. Unkind, even. You have oil and your sister does not — and you will not share? What happened to love your neighbor?

But the wise virgins were not being selfish. They were being honest.

The oil in this parable is not a material resource that can be divided and redistributed. It represents something that each person must accumulate personally, over time, through the daily practice of faith. You cannot hand it across at midnight because it does not transfer. It was never a commodity. It was a condition.

Think of it this way. A man who has spent forty years learning to be patient cannot give you his patience in a crisis. A woman who has spent a lifetime building deep and resilient faith cannot lend you hers when yours runs out. These things are not transferable because they are not things. They are the accumulated result of a thousand small choices made over a long time in ordinary circumstances.

This is one of the hardest truths in the parable, and we resist it because our instinct is to believe that the community of faith should compensate for individual deficiency. And it can — up to a point.

The church is real. The body of Christ matters. We carry one another's burdens and that is right and good.

But there is a limit. And the limit is this: in the moment of ultimate testing, each person faces it with what they actually have, not with what they wish they had or what they borrowed from someone else's store.

The midnight cry is not the time to start filling your lamp. It is the time to discover whether you already have.

The wise virgins' refusal is not cruelty. It is clarity. They cannot give what they have because what they have is not separable from who they are. And the most loving thing they can do for the foolish ones is to tell them the truth: go and buy for yourselves. There is still time. Go now.

The foolish ones went. But while they went, the bridegroom came.

This is the mechanism of the parable. Not punishment. Just consequence. The door closes not because anyone wanted to exclude them but because they were not there when the moment came.

The question for the reader is simple, urgent, and personal: what are you accumulating right now, in the ordinary days before the midnight cry? What kind of oil are you building up through prayer, through the word, through faithfulness in the small things, through loving the people in front of you?

You cannot borrow it when you need it. You can only have it if you built it.

Start now. The night is long, but it is not infinite.

Chapter 3

While the Bridegroom Tarried

> *"While the bridegroom tarried, they all slumbered and slept."*
> — Matthew 25:5

He didn't come when expected. What faithfulness looks like in the long wait.

The bridegroom is late. This is not incidental to the parable — it is the engine of it. If he had come on time, there would be no story. The story exists precisely because he tarried.

And in the gap, they all slept.

Notice that the parable does not condemn them for sleeping. It does not say the wise virgins stayed awake and vigilant while the foolish ones dozed. It says they all slumbered. The sleep is not the problem. The oil is the problem, or rather the absence of it. Sleeping was appropriate. The hour was late. Bodies need rest. The wise virgins could sleep and be ready because they had prepared before they lay down.

This is a more realistic portrait of the faithful life than we usually allow ourselves. We tend to imagine that faithfulness means constant vigilance, perpetual alertness, eyes always open and scanning the horizon. The parable suggests something different: faithful people sleep, rest, live their ordinary lives, do not spend every waking moment in a state of spiritual anxiety. What marks them is not that they never close their eyes but that they were ready before they did.

The long wait is one of the central challenges of Christian life, and it is one we talk about least. The first generation of believers expected

the return within their lifetime. Generation after generation since then has lived with the same expectation and the same disappointment. Two thousand years is a long time to stay awake.

And yet the parable says: while the bridegroom tarried. Not if. While. The delay is built into the story, expected, accounted for. The question is not whether you will have to wait. The question is what condition you will be in when the wait ends.

Faithfulness in the long wait looks like ordinary life lived well. It looks like keeping your lamp trimmed even when nothing seems to be happening. It looks like the daily practices of prayer and scripture and service and community, maintained not because they produce dramatic results but because they are what keep the oil topped up. It looks like not abandoning your post just because the master has not returned on your preferred schedule.

The bridegroom tarried. He tarried for the disciples who first heard this parable. He has tarried for every generation since.

He has not forgotten the appointment.

The question is whether we will be ready when he keeps it.

Chapter 4

The Midnight Cry

> *"And at midnight there was a cry made, Behold, the bridegroom cometh; go ye out to meet him."*
> — Matthew 25:6

Almost ready is the most dangerous distance from ready.

It comes at midnight. Not at noon, when everyone is alert and the path is clearly lit. Not at the appointed hour, when everyone had gathered in expectation. At midnight, when the wait had stretched past the point of comfortable anticipation into something that felt more like indefinite suspension.

This is how these things work. The critical moments in life rarely arrive on schedule. They come when we are tired, when our guard is down, when we have just begun to think that perhaps this particular test will not come after all. The phone call. The diagnosis. The news that changes everything. The moment that separates before from after.

Almost ready is, at that moment, not ready at all.

We tell ourselves that almost counts. That good intentions bridge the gap. That surely there will be a few extra minutes to make up the difference. But midnight does not negotiate. The midnight cry gives you exactly enough time to do one thing: discover whether you have what you need.

The parable is not designed to make us anxious. It is designed to make us serious about the present moment. Not about some future

state of readiness we plan to achieve, but about the actual condition of our faith and our lives right now.

Because the cry comes at midnight. And midnight comes faster than we think.

There is mercy in the warning. Jesus tells us this story precisely so that we can hear the cry before it comes and use the time we have. The parable is not about condemnation. It is about opportunity. You are still in the daylight hours. The oil is still available. The preparation can still be made.

The midnight cry, when it comes, will not sound like a warning. It will sound like a summons. The question is whether you will be running toward it or scrambling for what you should have had all along.

Use the daylight well.

Chapter 5

I Know You Not

> *"But he answered and said, Verily I say unto you, I know you not."*
> — Matthew 25:12

They were at the right place. They just weren't known.

Five words. The most terrifying five words in Matthew 25, and possibly in the entire gospel.

Not: you were wicked. Not: you failed the test. Not: you were found unworthy. Simply: I know you not. You are a stranger to me. Whatever your proximity to the door, whatever your familiarity with the language and the customs and the forms of faith — I do not know you.

This is the final movement of the parable, and it lands differently depending on where you are standing. To those who have cultivated a genuine relationship with the living God, it is a warning against mistaking familiarity for intimacy — against knowing about him without being known by him. To those who have never thought carefully about the distinction, it may be a shock.

The foolish virgins were not strangers to the faith. They were waiting at the right door. They had the right lamps. They were expecting the right bridegroom. By any external measure, they belonged. They had every marker of membership.

But the bridegroom's criterion was not membership. It was relationship. And relationship cannot be faked at midnight.

This is the deepest challenge in the parable. We live in a world that rewards the performance of belonging. We learn the vocabulary, adopt the practices, attend the gatherings, and over time we can become so fluent in the forms of faith that we forget to ask whether the substance is there.

The substance is relationship. It is the thing that cannot be borrowed or improvised or performed. It is what grows, slowly and invisibly, through the daily habit of coming to God not with religious duty but with honest need. Through praying not because it is the right thing to do but because there is no one else you trust with what is actually happening in your life. Through reading the word not to check a box but because you have discovered that it says something true about you.

Proximity is not intimacy. You can stand at the door without being known.

The question the parable ends with is not whether you know the right things. It is whether you are known. Whether the relationship is real enough, personal enough, honest enough to survive the moment when the bridegroom looks up and meets your eyes.

I know you not is not the end he wants for anyone. That is why the parable exists. Hear it while there is still time to answer it.

PART TWO

Work

The Talents — Matthew 25:14–30

Chapter 6

To Every Man According to His Ability

> *"...to every man according to his several ability."*
> — Matthew 25:15

The distribution is not unfair. He gave you exactly what he knows you can handle.

The master does not distribute equally. This is the first thing to reckon with in the parable of the talents, and it is the thing that makes many of us uncomfortable. Five talents to one, two to another, one to a third. Different amounts, different levels of trust, different expectations.

We want to call this unfair. We have been raised in a world that prizes equality of treatment, and the master's distribution looks like favoritism. But the parable inserts a single phrase that changes everything: according to his several ability.

He knew what each servant could handle. The distribution was not random, not arbitrary, not a test of whether the servants could cope with injustice. It was calibrated. The master looked at each of his servants and gave each one exactly the weight they were built to carry.

This means that comparison is worse than useless in the kingdom. The servant with two talents is not a lesser servant than the one with five. He received less because he was given what he could multiply, not what would crush him. And when he returns his two talents with two more, the master does not say well done, good enough. He says the same thing he said to the five-talent servant: well done, good and faithful servant. Enter into the joy of your lord.

The same words. The same invitation. The same joy. Because the criterion was never the size of the gift. It was the faithfulness with which it was used.

This should be liberating for anyone who has spent their life measuring themselves against people who seem to have been given more. You were not given less because you are valued less. You were given what the master knows you can multiply. The question is not whether your portion is large enough. The question is what you will do with what you have.

Comparison robs us of the particular joy of our own faithfulness. The servant with two talents could have spent his time resenting the servant with five. Instead, he went and traded. And in going and trading, he discovered something the bitter and the resentful never do: the joy of working well with what you've been given.

You have been given something. It is exactly right for you. The master is away.

What will you do with it?

Chapter 7

They Went and Traded

> *"Then he that had received the five talents went and traded with the same, and made them other five talents."*
>
> — Matthew 25:16

They moved immediately. No committee, no plan, no conditions. They just went.

Watch the grammar. Then he that had received the five talents went and traded. No pause. No deliberation. No mention of a plan, a strategy, a period of discernment, a committee formed to study the best use of the master's resources.

He went.

The same construction appears for the two-talent servant. He also gained two more. Same immediacy. Same swift movement between receiving and acting. The parable is not interested in the method. It is interested in the motion. They received something and they moved.

We have constructed entire industries around the space between receiving and moving. Books, seminars, retreats, frameworks, assessments, coaches, consultants — all designed to help us figure out what to do with what we have been given before we actually start doing it. Some of this is wisdom. Planning is not sin. Preparation is, as we have already seen, a virtue.

But there is a kind of planning that is really a form of avoidance. It feels like responsibility — I am not rushing in, I am being thoughtful, I am waiting until I am sure — but it produces the same result as burying the talent in the ground: nothing moves.

The two faithful servants did not wait for perfect conditions. They did not wait until the market was favorable, until they had more experience, until they felt ready. They received a trust and they honored that trust by putting it immediately into motion.

The kingdom works this way. What God has given you is not a deposit to be protected. It is a seed to be planted. Seeds are not valuable in the ground. They are valuable in the ground with water and sunlight and time — and that process cannot begin until someone puts the seed where it belongs.

You know what you have been given. You have known for a while. The question the parable presses on you is not whether you have a plan. The question is whether you went.

The master will not ask you how good your plan was. He will ask what you did with what you had.

Go.

Chapter 8

I Was Afraid

> *"And I was afraid, and went and hid thy talent in the earth."*
>
> — Matthew 25:25

Fear is the most honest chapter in this book, because most of us are this servant.

Here is the thing about the one-talent servant that we never want to say out loud: his reasoning is not crazy.

He knew his master. He had observed him. He had come to conclusions about what kind of man he was dealing with. A hard man, he says. Someone who reaps where he has not sown, who gathers where he has not scattered. Someone demanding and exacting. And so he was afraid. And being afraid, he did the most careful, the most conservative, the most apparently responsible thing he could think of: he preserved what he had been given. He did not spend it. He did not lose it. He put it somewhere safe and he kept it safe and when the master returned he gave it back, intact.

This is the logic of fear. Fear does not tell us we are abandoning our post. It tells us we are being prudent. It tells us we are protecting something valuable. It tells us that the risks of action outweigh the risks of inaction, and that the truly wise thing is to wait, to hold, to preserve, to not make things worse.

And in the economy of the kingdom, this is exactly wrong.

The master's rebuke is sharp, but notice what he does not dispute. He does not say you misunderstood me, I am actually quite gentle. He essentially accepts the servant's characterization and says: given

everything you believed about me, why did you not at least put the money to the exchangers? Why did fear produce paralysis rather than at least minimal action?

Because fear that produces paralysis is not really about protecting the master's investment. It is about protecting yourself. The one-talent servant did not bury the money to serve his master. He buried it so that he would have something to hand back. The burial was self-protective, not master-focused.

This is the test that fear fails. Genuine stewardship asks: what does the master need from me? Fear asks: what is the safest thing I can do for myself?

Most of us are the one-talent servant far more often than we want to admit. We have gifts we have not deployed because we are not sure they are good enough. We have callings we have not answered because we cannot guarantee the outcome. We have things to say that we have not said because we might be wrong, might be laughed at, might fail in public.

And so we bury them. Carefully. Safely. Preserving them against a day when conditions will be better.

The master returns and finds the ground undisturbed.

Fear is real. But it is not an excuse. It is the problem the parable is diagnosing.

What have you buried?

Chapter 9

Faithful Over a Few Things

> *"Thou hast been faithful over a few things, I will make thee ruler over many things."*
> — Matthew 25:21

Small faithfulness is the prerequisite for large trust. You don't get the bigger assignment first.

The economy of the kingdom runs exactly opposite to the economy of the world.

In the world, we demonstrate our capacity by performing large. We build a resume that shows impressive things done in impressive settings. We signal readiness for bigger responsibilities by acquiring credentials, titles, and associations that imply we are serious people capable of serious work.

The kingdom starts smaller than that. Faithful over a few things is both the requirement and the qualification. Not faithful over many things. Not faithful in visible things. Not faithful in ways that others noticed and rewarded. Faithful over a few things, in the ordinary scope of what you were given, with nobody watching.

This is good news for people who feel like their life is small. If what God is looking for before he expands the trust is faithfulness in the current small thing, then the most important work you will do this week may look utterly unremarkable. Keeping a promise. Doing a job well when no one would know if you did it poorly. Showing up for someone who cannot repay you. Maintaining integrity in a small decision that seems to matter to no one.

These are the few things. And faithfulness in them is the condition for the many.

We resist this because we want the many first. We want the big assignment, the broad platform, the significant impact — and then we will show the faithfulness. But the parable says it works the other way. The few things are not the waiting room for the real life. They are the real life. They are where the character is formed that will determine what you do with more.

The servant who was faithful with five talents was faithful with five. Not with fifty, not with five hundred. Five. And because he was faithful there, the master trusted him with the larger thing.

What are your few things? They may not feel like much. They are almost certainly not impressive. They may be things that no one else would even notice if you stopped doing them.

Do them faithfully. The master notices.

Chapter 10

Enter Into the Joy

> *"...enter thou into the joy of thy lord."*
> — Matthew 25:21

The reward is not more stuff or more responsibility. It is presence. It is him.

The master does not say: well done, here is your bonus. He does not say: well done, your performance review is excellent and you have been approved for a promotion. He says: enter into the joy of your lord.

The reward is not a thing. It is a where. It is a with.

Enter into the joy. The servant is being invited to come inside something the master is already experiencing. The joy exists independently of the servant's performance — it is the master's joy, and the faithful servant is now permitted to step into it, to inhabit it, to live within it as though it were a room.

This changes what faithfulness is for. We tend to think of faithful work as earning something: a reward, a rest, a recognition. And there is a sense in which the parable supports that — the faithful servant receives something the unfaithful servant does not. But the thing received is not compensation. It is communion. The point of all the trading and working and multiplying was not to produce a result the servant could be proud of. It was to bring the servant into a relationship with the master's own delight.

This is where the parable becomes genuinely good news rather than just a demanding text. The faithful life is not a long slog toward a distant payoff. It is a gradual entering into a joy that is already

there, that the master is already in, that every act of faithfulness brings us slightly closer to.

The servant who traded with five talents and gained five more did not just double the money. He spent time in the master's business, thinking the master's thoughts, bearing the master's risk, working toward the master's goals. And in doing so, he became more like the master. He entered, in a small way, into the master's experience of the world.

That is what faithfulness produces. Not just results. Resemblance.

The invitation at the end is the invitation the entire parable has been building toward. Not well done, go collect your reward. Well done, come be with me. Come into what I am already experiencing. The distance between you and my joy has been decreasing all this time. Enter now into what has been prepared for you from the beginning.

This is what all the working was for. Not the work itself. The one who waits for the work to be done.

PART THREE

Serve

The Sheep and Goats — Matthew 25:31–46

Chapter 11

When Saw We Thee?

> *"Then shall the righteous answer him, saying, Lord, when saw we thee an hungred, and fed thee?"*
> — Matthew 25:37

Both sides ask the same question and mean opposite things. The surprise is total.

The most striking feature of the sheep and goats passage is one we almost always overlook: both sides are surprised.

We read the parable expecting one group to be aware of what they did and one group to be in denial about what they didn't. We expect the sheep to say yes, Lord, we saw you — we knew all along. And we expect the goats to make excuses, to argue, to point to the things they did do.

But that is not what happens. Both sides ask the same question: Lord, when? When did we see you? The sheep are not claiming credit. They are genuinely puzzled. When were you hungry and we fed you? We don't remember that. We remember feeding hungry people, but not you.

And the goats are not making excuses. They are also genuinely puzzled. When did we fail to serve you? We would have served you. If we had known it was you, we would certainly have acted differently.

Both answers reveal the same truth about how they lived: neither group was performing for an audience. Neither group was calculating the spiritual return on their investment. The sheep served because serving was who they were. The goats didn't serve because not

serving was who they were. In both cases, the behavior was so natural that it left no memorable impression of moral significance.

This is the deepest teaching in the passage. Genuine character is not what you do when you know you are being watched or graded. It is what you do automatically, without calculation, without awareness that it matters.

The sheep were not trying to serve Christ. They were just trying to serve people. The love was so habitual, so integrated into their way of moving through the world, that they did not experience it as a distinct spiritual act. It was just what they did.

The question this poses is uncomfortable: what do you do automatically? What is so integrated into your character that you don't notice it as a choice? Because that — not your aspirations, not your best moments, not your public demonstrations of virtue — is who you actually are.

Lord, when saw we thee?

The answer is: always. He was there every time. The question is what you did when you saw him without knowing it was him.

Chapter 12

The Six Faces of the Master

> *"For I was an hungred, and ye gave me meat: I was thirsty, and ye gave me drink: I was a stranger, and ye took me in: Naked, and ye clothed me: I was sick, and ye visited me: I was in prison, and ye came unto me."*
>
> — Matthew 25:35-36

Not a metaphor. A field guide. The master is already here.

Six faces. Six conditions. Six specific, concrete, un-metaphorical ways that the Son of Man is present in the world right now, today, in your town, on your street, in the places you drive past without stopping.

Hungry. Thirsty. A stranger. Naked. Sick. Imprisoned.

We have developed a robust tradition of spiritualizing these categories — the hunger is for meaning, the thirst is for truth, the stranger is the person who feels spiritually isolated. There may be some value in these readings. But they carry a risk: they let us off the hook for the literal version. And Jesus is resolutely literal here. He is talking about people who need food. People who need water. People who are foreign-born and unwelcome. People who do not have adequate clothing. People whose bodies are failing. People locked in cages.

These are not metaphors. They are a field guide.

The King identifies himself completely with people in these six conditions. Not symbolically. Not analogically. Actually. What you do to them, you do to him. What you withhold from them, you withhold

from him. The identification is so complete that the distinction between the person in front of you and the King on the throne has, in these six categories, effectively collapsed.

This should change how we move through the world. It should change what we see when we drive through certain neighborhoods, what we feel when we pass someone holding a sign, what we do when we hear about the conditions in the local jail or the local hospital or the shelter three miles from the church.

He is in those places. Not in some vague spiritual sense. In the people who are suffering in those places, the King is present, waiting to be recognized, waiting to be served, waiting to see whether those who call themselves his servants will actually act like it when the stakes are invisible and the return is non-existent.

The church has a long history of charity that begins and ends with financial donations. This is not nothing. Food banks need money. Shelters need funding. But the parable specifies something more personal than a donation: I was sick and ye visited me. Not donated to the hospital fund. Visited. Present. There.

The six faces of the master are everywhere. The question is whether we are looking.

Chapter 13

Inasmuch

> *"Verily I say unto you, Inasmuch as ye have done it unto one of the least of these my brethren, ye have done it unto me."*
>
> — Matthew 25:40

The hinge word of the entire chapter. The equation is simple and impossible to avoid.

Inasmuch. As much as. To the degree that. In proportion to.

It is a word of equivalence. It does not say that serving the hungry is like serving Christ in some illustrative sense. It says that serving the hungry is serving Christ in an actual sense. The equation is one-to-one. Full exchange rate. No diminishment.

This one word is the hinge on which the entire chapter turns. The parable of the virgins tells us to watch because the master is coming. The parable of the talents tells us to work because the master has given us something to multiply. This parable tells us something neither of the first two explicitly say: the master is already here. He has not departed and not yet returned. He is present now, in the world, wearing the faces of the least of these.

Inasmuch carries enormous implications for what we call "social justice" or "care for the poor" or "mercy ministry." In many Christian communities, these activities are treated as optional extras — admirable if you feel called to them, but not central to the faith. The person who teaches Sunday school and the person who serves at the soup kitchen are both doing fine work, but the implication is that one is doing specifically spiritual work and the other is doing generally good work.

Matthew 25:40 does not support this hierarchy. The person at the soup kitchen is serving Christ. Not approximately. Not symbolically. Actually, directly, with the same one-to-one exchange rate as the person who serves in the most explicitly religious context. Inasmuch.

This should also humble us about the inverse. Inasmuch as ye did it not to one of the least of these, ye did it not to me. Every time we passed by. Every time we looked away. Every time we told ourselves it was not our responsibility, not our lane, not our problem. Every time the uncomfortable need was allowed to remain unmet because meeting it would have cost us something.

Inasmuch. The same exchange rate in both directions.

This is not a comfortable word. But it is a clarifying one. It simplifies a lot of complicated theology into a single question: in proportion to how much you have served the least of these, that is how much you have served me.

The least of these are everywhere.

Inasmuch.

Chapter 14

These Shall Go Away

> *"And these shall go away into everlasting punishment: but the righteous into life eternal."*
> — Matthew 25:46

Omission is not neutral. The goats didn't do anything terrible. That was exactly the problem.

We have a category in our moral imaginations for people who do terrible things. We know what to make of cruelty, violence, deliberate harm. We have names for these sins and appropriate horror for the people who commit them.

We have a much less developed category for people who simply do not act.

The goats in this parable are not villains. They did not hurt anyone. They did not steal from the hungry or mock the stranger or torment the sick. They simply went about their lives without reference to the six faces of the master. The hungry remained hungry. The stranger remained unwelcome. The imprisoned remained alone. Not because the goats actively prevented help, but because the goats were not the kind of people who noticed, who stopped, who changed direction.

And this, the parable says, is enough to constitute a verdict.

We resist this. It seems disproportionate. How can the absence of action carry the same weight as the commission of evil? But Jesus is teaching something here about the nature of love that our passive categories of morality cannot contain. Love is not the absence of harm. Love is active. It seeks out the need. It goes toward the suffering. It changes its plans when it encounters a face it recognizes.

The goats did not love, because love would have looked like something. Love would have produced visits and meals and welcome and clothing and presence. The absence of these things is not neutral. It is the evidence of an absent love.

This is perhaps the hardest teaching in the chapter for comfortable, well-meaning, generally decent people. The parable is not primarily addressed to the openly wicked. It is addressed to people who thought they were fine. People who had not done anything wrong. People who attended the right events and held the right beliefs and lived respectable lives.

And who had not fed anyone. Had not welcomed anyone. Had not visited anyone.

These shall go away. Not because they were terrible. Because they were absent.

The omissions we are least aware of may be the ones that matter most.

Conclusion: The Servant's Goal

> *"Watch therefore... enter thou into the joy... inasmuch as ye have done it..."*
> — Matthew 25

Watch. Work. Serve. Three answers to one question.

We began with a question: what does a faithful servant do while the master is away?

Matthew 25 has answered it three times, from three different angles, using three different stories. And now, at the end, the three answers need to be held together, because they are not three separate instructions. They are one life, viewed from three perspectives.

The servant who watches is the servant who has oil in her lamp. She has spent the long wait not in anxious vigilance but in steady preparation — daily, ordinary, unspectacular faithfulness that accumulates into a reserve deep enough to survive the midnight cry. She sleeps when she needs to sleep. She does not burn herself out in performed alertness. But she has what she needs when the moment comes, because she built it before she needed it.

The servant who works is the servant who received a trust and immediately put it into motion. He did not bury what he was given. He did not wait for better conditions or clearer instructions or a sign that the risk was acceptable. He understood that a trust is not a deposit to be protected but a seed to be planted, and that seeds must do their work in the ground. He went and traded, and in going and trading he entered gradually into the master's own experience of the

work — until the day when the master looked at him and said: enter into the joy. Come the rest of the way in.

The servant who serves is the servant who moves through the world with her eyes open. She has not become so focused on her own readiness or her own fruitfulness that she stops seeing the people in front of her. She feeds the hungry because they are hungry. She welcomes the stranger because he is a stranger. She visits the sick because they are alone. She does none of this thinking about the exchange rate, the theological significance, the merit she may be accumulating. She does it because loving people is who she is, and she has been who she is for long enough that she cannot remember when she decided to become this way.

And one day, in the moment of final accounting, she is surprised to learn that every meal she prepared, every door she opened, every hour she sat beside someone who could not repay her — was a meal prepared for the King, a door opened for the King, an hour given to the King.

This is the servant's goal. Not achievement. Not recognition. Not a flawless record of spiritual performance. The goal is to be so thoroughly oriented toward the master — watching for his return, working with his resources, seeing his face in the world around you — that when he finally walks back through the door, you are not scrambling to present your credentials. You are simply standing there, lamp lit, talent multiplied, hands still warm from the last person you served.

And he looks at you and says: I know you.

Enter into the joy.

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Matthew 25 is not primarily a warning text, though it contains warnings. It is an invitation. The master left us with enough — enough time, enough resource, enough of his own presence in the world around us — to spend the gap between his going and his coming in a way that is worthy of what he did before he left.

Watch. Work. Serve.

These are not three more things on the list. They are one thing: the life of a person who has understood what has been given and what is required, and who has decided to spend the time accordingly.

The master is away.

He will return.

This is what to do with everything in between.

About the Author

Bill Wear is an Electrical Engineer, technical writer, developer advocate, and occasional accidental physicist based in Crane Creek, Mississippi. More importantly, he is a Christian who strives not to do what Jesus *would* do, but what Jesus *told us to do*. He has spent over fifty years in technology and another lifetime in the church, and has concluded that the best things in both worlds share a common foundation: clarity, honesty, and the willingness to follow an idea wherever it actually leads.

He lives with his wife Sharan of thirty-four years and a Bombay cat named Baby.